Taijuan Walker, Phillie

Four years, $72 million, and the gap the strikeouts never explained

Prepared for: front office, pitching department, pro scouting · **Throws:** R · **MLBAM:** 592836 **Governance:** UC #62 · uc-pps-038 · dp_uc62 v1.0.0 · Phillies Pitching (pps) · house log anchor 2026-10-01. KPIs inherited by import from the `dp_uc53` chain (sha-pinned); new and provisional: KR-1, CE-1, PR-1.

Read this first: data window and sample sizes.

- MLB regular season 2015–26, locked to MLBAM 592836. SEA/ARI/TOR/NYM years come from his pitcher-keyed file plus pitcher-id rows in other opponent files; Phillies years from the house log. Postseason excluded.
- 2018 (56 PA) and 2019 (4 PA) are in the totals but out of every season-level chart and rank. 2026 is 115 PA.
- Innings are outs from the log (OU-2) and reconcile exactly to public IP: 172.2 + 83.2 + 123.2 + 22.2 = 402.2. ERA, contract terms and the Angels timeline are labelled carry-ins (CI-1..CI-6), never computed on.
- Ranks use the Phillies pitcher-season pool 2015–26 (≥100 PA, n = 198), not MLB.

Bottom line

The Phillies bought a pitcher who allowed less than his strikeouts said he should: in 2021–22 his wOBA ran .027 below the Phillies line for his K% (KR-1). Over the contract the strikeouts fell 4.5 pts, the four-seamer lost 1.8 mph, the splitter's whiff rate fell 6.6 pts, and the contact got harder (xwOBA +.033). The kind luck of the Mets years also went away. The pre-registered ledger calls it **both, and the price was set on a residual**. Two of his four Phillies seasons are among the three worst by a Phillies pitcher since 2015 (2026 #1, 2024 #3 of 198).

1. **What they got:** 1,772 batters faced (#8 of 199 Phillies pitchers since 2015), 172.2+83.2+123.2+22.2 IP = 402.2, reconciled to the out. One average season (2023, .311 wOBA, #109 of 198 from the bottom), one swing year (2025, .335), and two of the three worst Phillies pitcher-seasons on record here.
2. **What they bought:** a contact manager. At 21.4% K in 2021–22 the Phillies line expects .323; he allowed .296. Statcast agreed it was mostly real (xwOBA .317, luck gap −.008).
3. **What broke:** the stuff (H-S STRONG). K% 21.4%→16.9%, whiff 23.6%→18.9%, four-seam 94.2→92.4 mph, splitter whiff 28.2%→21.6%. He threw the four-seamer 63% of the time in 2015 and not at all in 2026.
4. **And the luck (H-L STRONG):** the gap between results and contact quality moved +.021. Context the ledger did not grade: his tenure gap (+.013) sits below the Phillies pool median (+.019). The luck did not turn bad; it stopped being good. 2026 is the exception (+.069 in 115 PA).
5. **What it cost (AAV basis, CE-1):** $179K per inning over the deal; $794K per inning and $157K per batter in 2026. Released April 23; two Angels minor-league deals; never promoted, so the Phillies paid the full $18M.

1 · What the Phillies got

Four seasons, 1,772 batters, #8 among 199 Phillies pitchers since 2015 in batters faced. 2023 was a Phillies-median rotation year: 31 starts, 172.2 IP, .311 wOBA (the pool median is .318). Then 2024 (.412, #3 worst of 198), a swingman 2025 (21 starts in 34 games, .335) and a five-game 2026 that is the worst Phillies pitcher-season in the sample (.455).

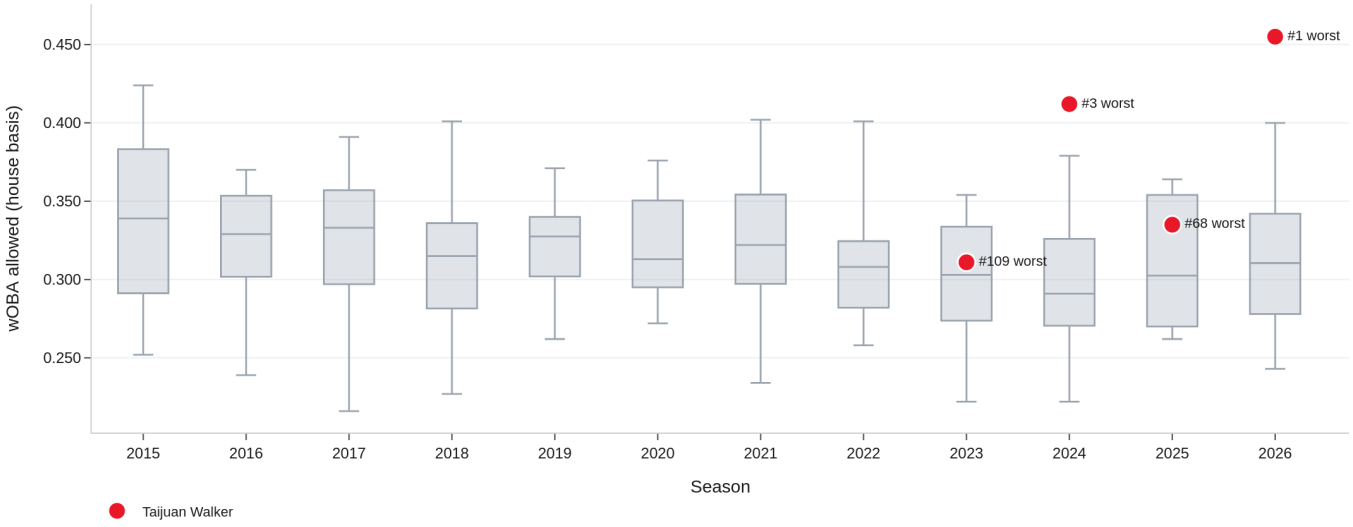
Season	Team	G (GS)	IP	BF	wOBA	Phillies rank (worst first)	xwOBA	K%	BB%	Whiff	Hard-hit	Barrel	Runs on watch / 27 outs
2015	SEA	29 (29)	167.1	705	.308	—	.318	22.3%	5.4%	23.5%	33.8%	7.6%	4.57
2016	SEA	25 (25)	132.2	573	.323	—	.323	20.8%	6.1%	22.5%	36.7%	9.0%	4.68
2017	ARI	28 (28)	156.1	676	.309	—	.316	21.6%	8.0%	21.7%	35.1%	5.1%	4.26

Season	Team	G (GS)	IP	BF	wOBA	Phillies rank (worst first)	xwOBA	K%	BB%	Whiff	Hard-hit	Barrel	Runs on watch / 27 outs
2020	SEA/ TOR	11 (11)	52.1	225	.291	—	.338	22.2%	8.4%	20.5%	32.9%	7.2%	3.44
2021	NYM	30 (30)	156.1	654	.300	—	.326	22.3%	8.4%	23.6%	39.4%	10.0%	4.49
2022	NYM	29 (29)	154.2	648	.293	—	.308	20.4%	6.8%	23.6%	40.6%	7.3%	3.32
2023	PHI	31 (31)	172.2	736	**.311**	#109 of 198	.322	18.8%	9.5%	20.5%	40.9%	6.8%	4.27
2024	PHI	19 (15)	83.2	382	**.412**	#3 of 198	.401	15.2%	9.7%	16.7%	46.3%	13.4%	7.31
2025	PHI	34 (21)	123.2	539	**.335**	#68 of 198	.337	16.0%	7.8%	18.5%	41.4%	7.4%	4.29
2026	PHI	5 (4)	22.2	115	**.455**	#1 of 198	.411	14.8%	9.6%	16.8%	36.0%	12.8%	9.93

House wOBA (K44 nresults) for wOBA and ranks; xwOBA is XW-1. Runs on watch include unearned runs scored during his PAs.

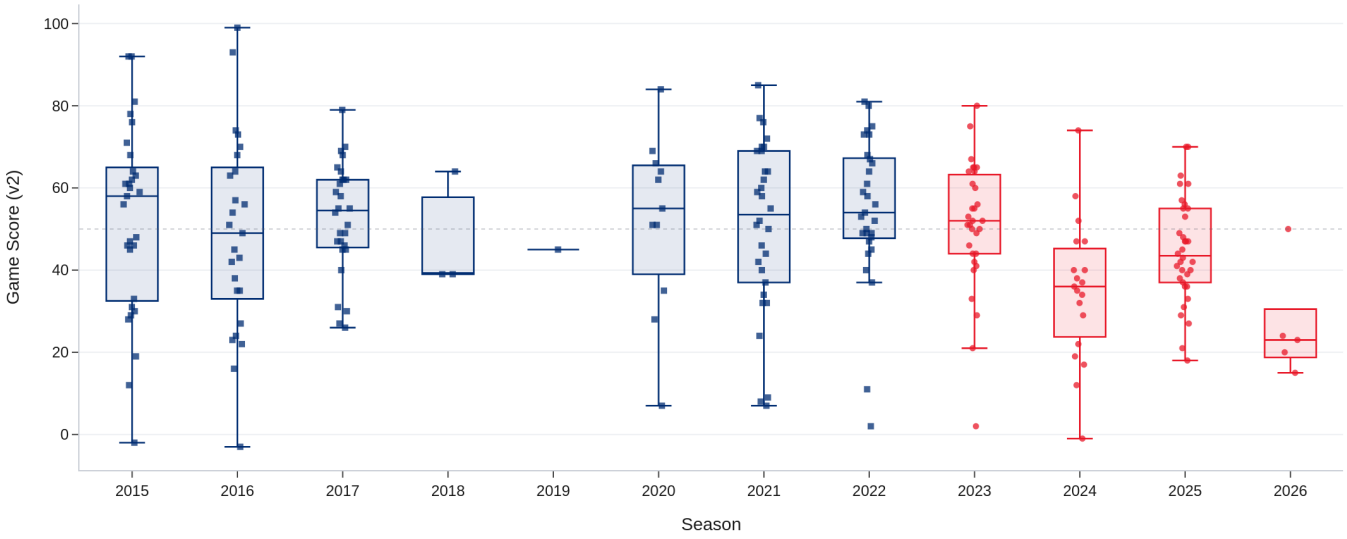
Where his Phillies seasons sit in Phillies history

wOBA allowed, Phillies pitcher-seasons 2015–26 (≥100 PA, n = 198), box per season; Walker marked with his rank from the worst.



Every appearance by Game Score (GS-1), 2015–26

Tango Game Score v2 per appearance; box = his season's middle 50%. Red = Phillies seasons.

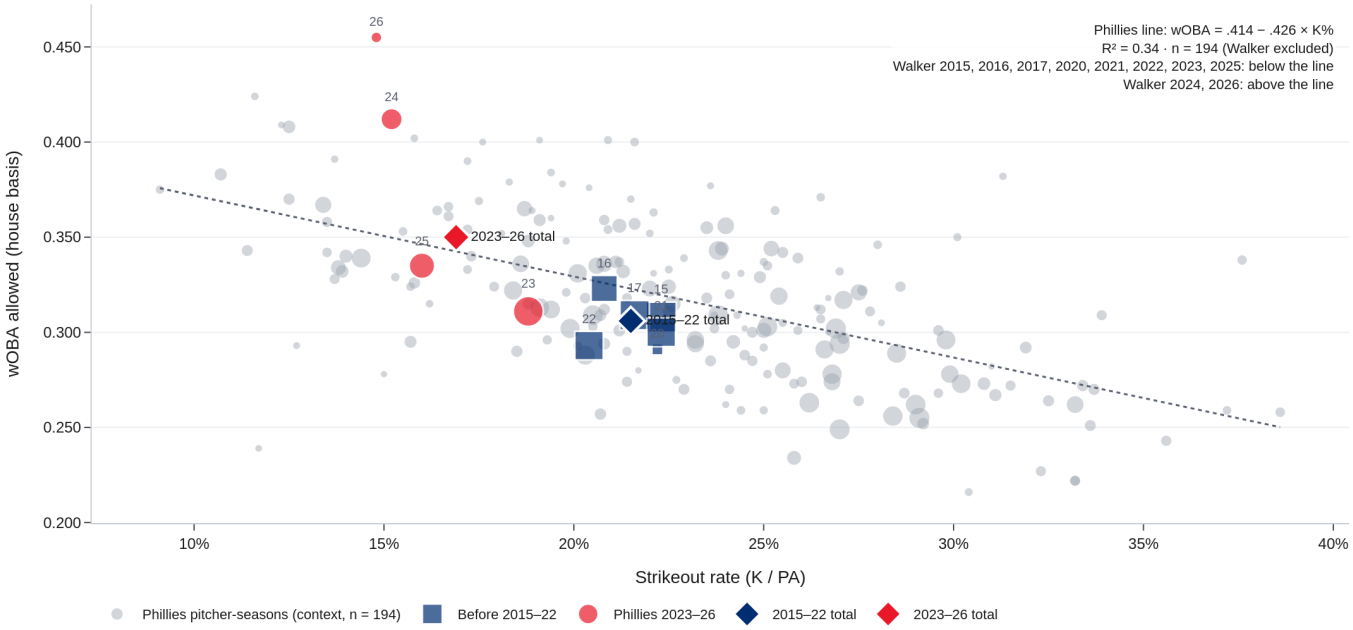


2 · What they bought

The client's chart, rebuilt on the governed pool. The Phillies line is wOBA = .414 − .426 × K% (R² 0.34, n = 194, Walker excluded). Every Walker season from 2015 to 2023 sits below it. 2021–22, the seasons that priced the contract, sat .027 below: a pitcher whose run prevention his strikeouts did not explain. Statcast's contact model said most of that was real (luck gap −.008), which is why it was easy to pay for.

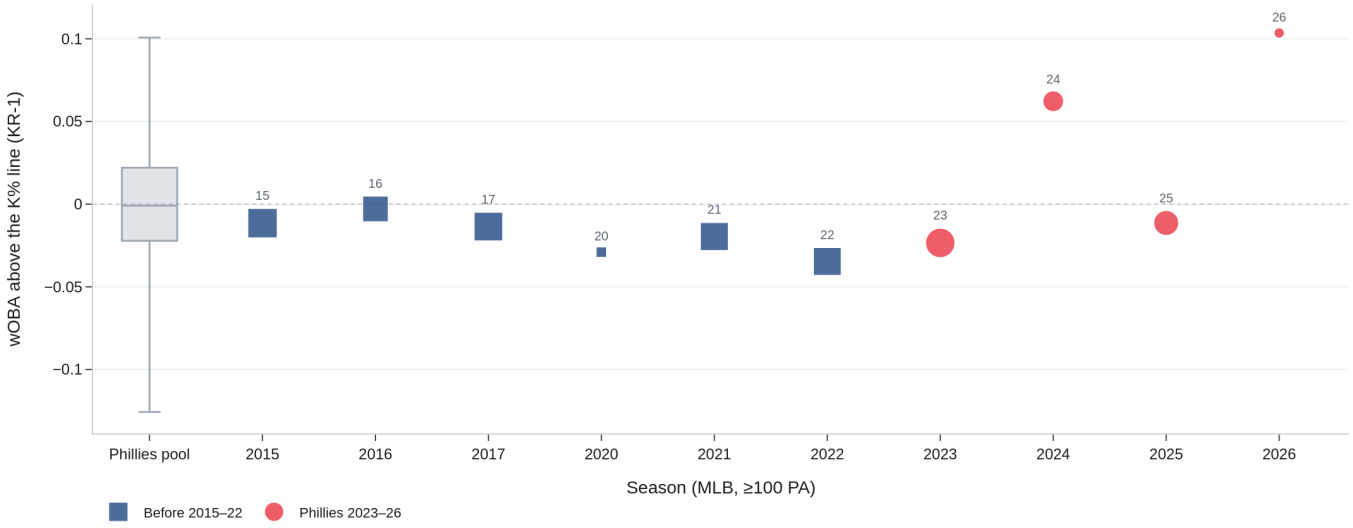
The client's chart, governed: wOBA allowed as a function of K%

Phillies pitcher-seasons 2015–26 (≥100 PA, Walker excluded, n = 194) in gray; Walker's MLB seasons ≥100 PA in navy (before) and red (Phillies); diamonds = era totals. Dot size = PA.



KR-1: how far below (or above) the Phillies K% line each season landed

wOBA minus the wOBA the Phillies pool allows at that K%. Below zero = better than the strikeouts explain. Box = Phillies pool.



3 · What broke

Both pitches that carried the Mets years slipped. The four-seamer went from 94.2 mph in 2021–22 to 92.4 in the tenure, and from 30% usage to none in 2026. The splitter, his best pitch, lost 6.6 points of whiff rate. His three full Phillies splitters (2023–25) are the three lowest-whiff seasons among the 18 Phillies splitter-seasons since 2015 (≥150 thrown); 2024's was 16.3%. That year the sinker, his most-used pitch, allowed a .515 xwOBA on contact (78 balls in play).

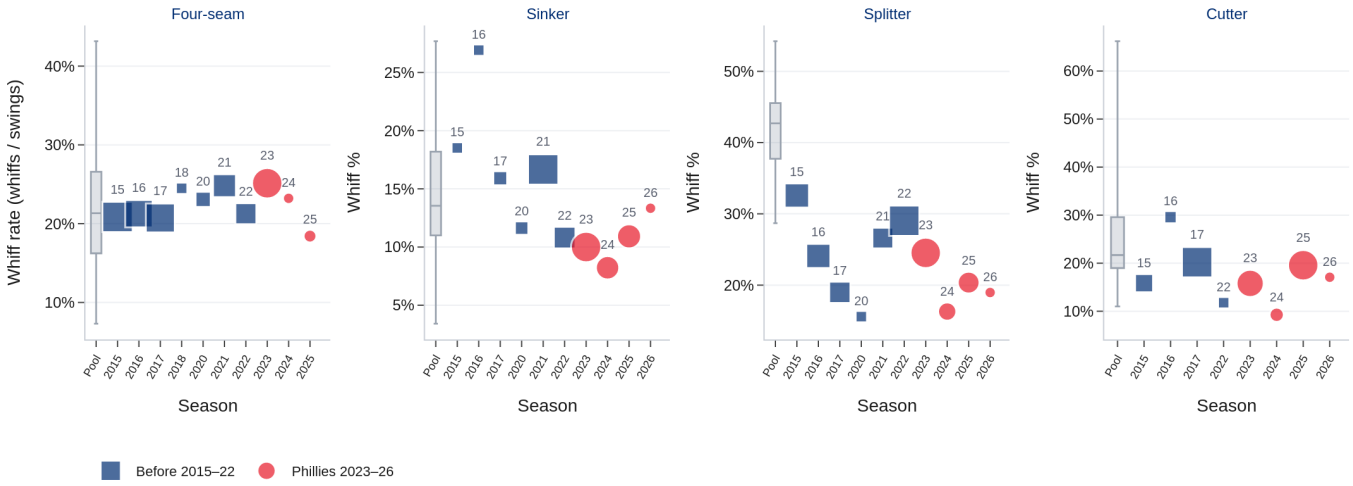
Velocity by pitch, every season

Mean release speed; pitch-seasons with ≥50 thrown. Box = Phillies pitcher-pitch-seasons 2015–26 (≥150 of that pitch).



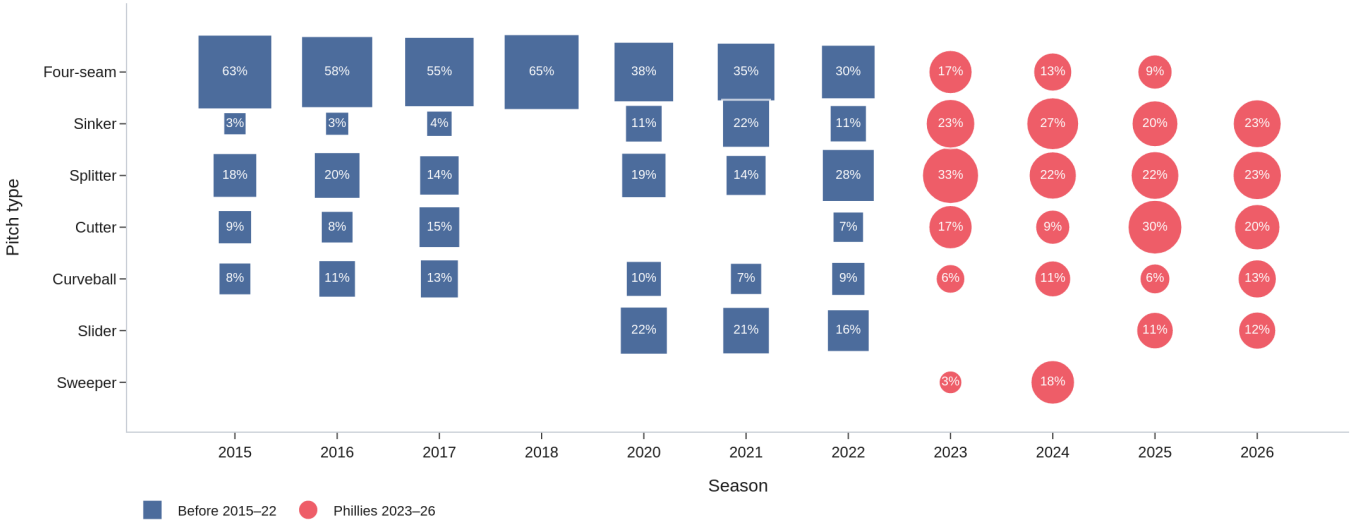
Whiff rate by pitch, every season

Whiffs / swings. Box = Phillies pitcher-pitch-seasons 2015–26 (≥150 of that pitch). Dot size = pitches thrown.



The arsenal migrated away from the four-seamer

Share of his pitches by type and season (pitch-seasons with ≥50 thrown). Bubble area = usage share; label = usage.

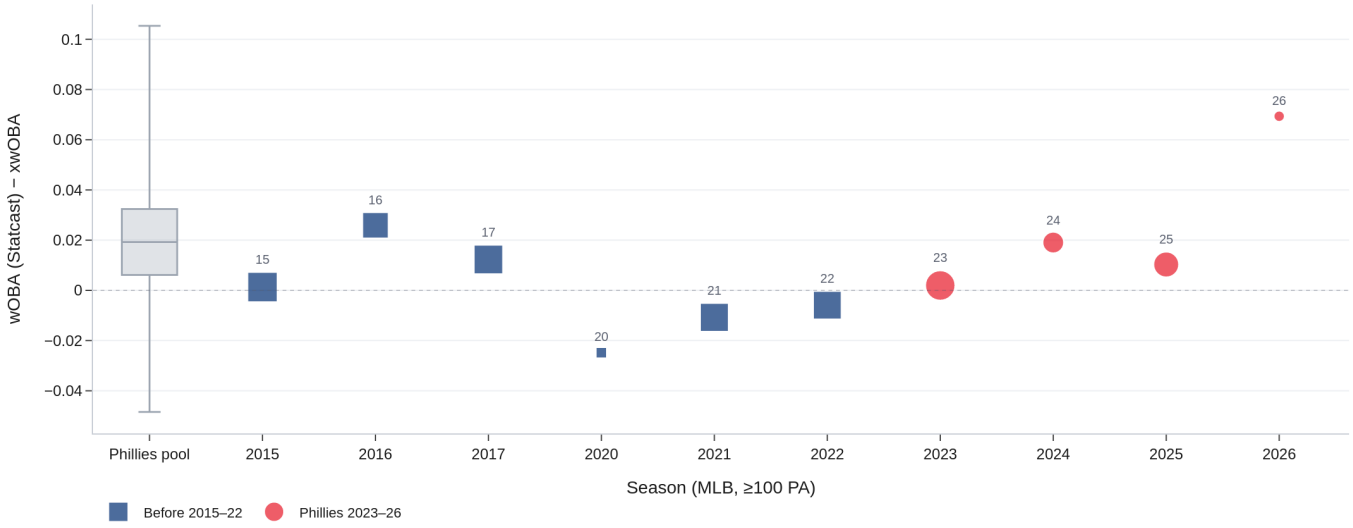


4 · Luck, measured

The pre-registered luck family is STRONG: his results-minus-contact gap rose +.021 from the Mets years. But the Phillies pool itself runs a +.019 median gap, and his tenure (+.013) is ordinary for a Phillie. The Mets years were the lucky ones. Only 2026 (+.069, 115 PA) was bad luck by Phillies standards, and it sat on the worst contact quality of his career (xwOBA .411).

Results against contact quality: wOBA (Statcast basis) minus xwOBA

Above zero = hitters out-hit their contact. Box = Phillies pool; its median sits above zero. Dot size = PA.



The pre-registered ledger (PR-1, filed 20:19 ET before any *unseen* signature was computed)

Family	Sig	Metric	Before	After	Bar	Verdict	Seen at T0
H-S	S1	krate	21.4% (2021–22)	16.9% (2023–26)	−3.0 pts	**PRESENT**	yes
H-S	S2	whiff_rate	23.6% (2021–22)	18.9% (2023–26)	−3.0 pts	**PRESENT**	yes
H-S	S3	ff_velo	94.2 mph (2021–22)	92.4 mph (2023–26)	−1.0 mph	**PRESENT**	no
H-S	S4	fs_whiff	28.2% (2021–22)	21.6% (2023–26)	−5.0 pts	**PRESENT**	no
H-S	S5	xwoba	.317 (2021–22)	.350 (2023–26)	+.025	**PRESENT**	no
H-L	L1	luck_gap	−.008 (2021–22)	.013 (2023–26)	+.015	**PRESENT**	no
H-L	L2	luck_gap	−.008 (2021–22)	.019 (2024)	+.020	**PRESENT**	no
H-R	R1	kr1	.000 (0)	−.027 (2021–22)	−.025	**PRESENT**	yes
H-R	R2	luck_gap	.000 (0)	−.008 (2021–22)	−.010	**WEAK**	no
H-R	R3	kr1	−.010 (2015–19)	−.027 (2021–22)	−.010	**PRESENT**	yes

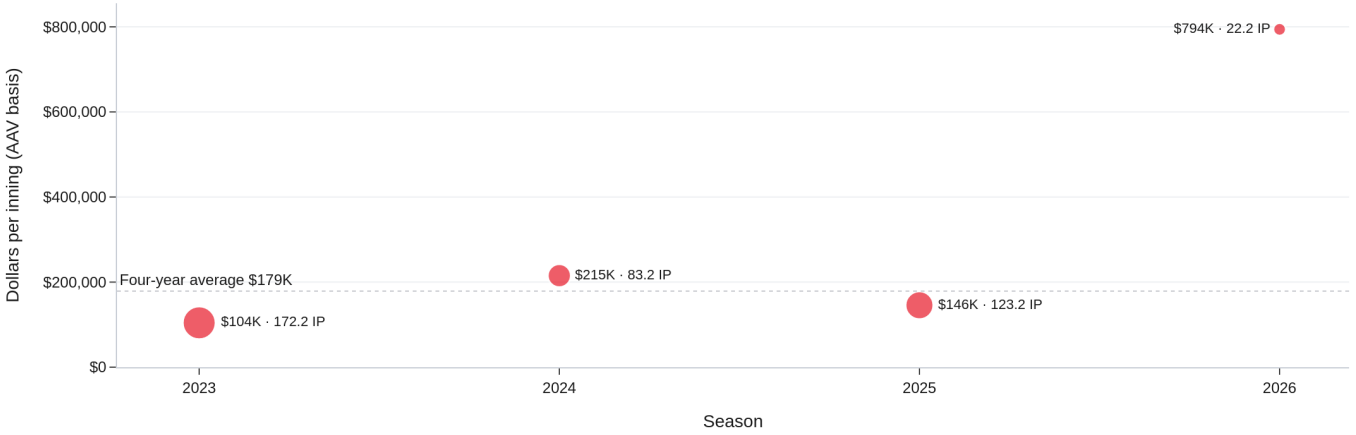
Roll-up: H-S **STRONG** · H-L **STRONG** · H-R **SUPPORTED** → call: **both, and the price was set on a residual**. R2 is WEAK: at signing his contact was not lucky by the zero bar, so most of the gap the Phillies paid for was real weak contact. It aged with the stuff.

5 · What it cost

On the AAV basis the deal bought innings at $179K each. 2023 was the bargain ($104K); 2026 cost $794K per inning for 22.2 innings and 115 batters.

CE-1: contract cost per inning, AAV basis

$18M AAV (carry-in CI-1) over innings from the log (OU-2, reconciled to public IP). Dotted line = the four-year average.



Season	IP (OU-2)	BF	$ per inning	$ per batter
2023	172.2	736	$104K	$24K
2024	83.2	382	$215K	$47K
2025	123.2	539	$146K	$33K
2026	22.2	115	$794K	$157K
2023-26	402.2	1772	$179K	$41K

AAV basis: $18M a season, $72M total (CI-1). Cash timing, deferrals and tax are out of scope.

6 · How it ended

Date	Opp	Role	IP	Pitches	H	HR	BB	K	Runs on watch	Game Score
2026-03-30	vs WSH	Start	4.2	99	10	0	3	2	7	23
2026-04-05	@ COL	Start	4.2	87	7	3	2	4	4	24
2026-04-11	vs AZ	Start	4.2	85	4	1	2	6	2	50
2026-04-17	vs ATL	Start	4.0	89	7	2	3	4	7	15
2026-04-22	@ CHC	Bulk relief	4.0	64	8	2	1	1	5	20

When	What (carry-ins)
2026-03-30 to 04-22	Five appearances: four starts and one bulk outing behind opener Kyle Backhus at Chicago (log). 9.13 ERA, 8 HR in 22.2 IP (CI-1).
2026-04-23	Released to clear a rotation spot for Zack Wheeler's return (CI-1). Phillies owe the rest of the $18M.
2026-05-23	Minor-league deal with the Angels (CI-4).
2026-06-08	Opts out; released (CI-2, CI-4).
2026-06-11	Second minor-league deal with the Angels, assigned to AAA Salt Lake (CI-3).
2026-06-21	Released again. Five starts across the Arizona Complex League and Salt Lake: 21 IP, 3.86 ERA, 12 K, 7 BB (CI-4). Never promoted.

7 · The client's claims, graded

HP	Claim	Grade	Evidence
HP-01	The client CSV reproduces (pitches, PA by season)	**CONFIRMED**	KF-1 frame matches the client CSV in 12/12 seasons; NF-1 dedup lost 483 pitches. Client vs governed pitches by season: {2015: -39, 2016: -35, 2017: -63, 2018: -11, 2019: 0, 2020: -5, 2021: -160, 2022: -122, 2023: 0, 2024: 0, 2025: 18, 2026: 0}. 2025 client row carries 18 postseason pitches (SRC-1).
HP-02		**CONFIRMED**	

HP	Claim	Grade	Evidence
	Paid nearly $18 million this season		CI-1: $18MM, final year of 4/$72MM. The Angels owed only the prorated minimum for MLB time, offset against the Phillies' payment; he never reached the majors (CI-4), so the Phillies paid all of it.
HP-03	To pitch in the Angels minor league system	**CONFIRMED (incomplete)**	Two minor-league deals (May 23, Jun 11), released Jun 8 (opt-out) and Jun 21; 5 starts, ACL + AAA Salt Lake, 21 IP (CI-4). Free agent after Jun 21; no later signing found.
HP-04	2026 worst, 2024 3rd-worst of 199 Phillies pitcher-seasons by wOBA	**CONFIRMED**	Governed pool n = 198 (regular season, >= 100 PA; turn 1 used games > 3 on the client frame, n = 199): 2026 #1, 2024 #3. Pool size restated 199 -> 198.
HP-05	Career split .303 (2015-22) vs .350 (2023-26)	**PARTLY**	Governed pooled nresults: before 0.306, tenure 0.350.
HP-06	2015 ev_mu 88.9 is a tracking artifact	**PARTLY (bar met; cause misattributed)**	Registered bar met: 2015 BIP EV-null share 2.2% = 2.4x 2016-22. But nulls cannot move a mean 5 mph. The client's ev_mu is `inds` = mean launch_speed over EVERY pitch with a reading. Non-BIP rows with an EV: 2015 16%, 2016 39%, 2022 46% (fouls/tips). BIP-only mean EV is flat: 2015 89.4, 2022 89.1. The 2015 spike is a population change in which pitches carry EV, not a sensor error.
HP-07	Code defects CR-1..CR-4	**CONFIRMED (3 of 4); CR-4 WITHDRAWN**	CR-1 `games > 3` drops 18 Phillies pitcher-seasons with exactly 3 games that the title includes. CR-2 the CSV has no career rows (all 12 Walker rows carry a game_year). CR-3 `inds` and `leadoff_walk_rate` columns are merged then dropped by `z[level+kpis]`. CR-4 px.scatter(subtitle=...) on plotly 6.0.1: accepted.

Takeaways

1. **The contract was priced on a real but fragile skill.** Walker's 2021–22 run prevention beat his strikeouts by .027, and Statcast mostly agreed. That kind of edge rides on fastball velocity and a put-away splitter. Both declined from the first Phillies season.
2. **The tell was visible in 2023.** The 31-start, 172.2-inning season hid a K% of 18.8% (down from 20.4%), a four-seam usage cut to 17% and a 9.5% walk rate. KR-1 still read −.023 that year; in 2024 it flipped to +.062.
3. **Don't blame luck.** His tenure results-minus-contact gap (+.013) was ordinary for a Phillie (pool median +.019). The Mets years were the outlier.
4. **For the next contact-manager contract:** require KR-1 and the luck gap to point the same way, and price the fastball's velocity trend as hard as the ERA.

Candid caveats

- **Ranks are Phillies-frame** (pitcher-seasons 2015–26, ≥100 PA, n = 198), not MLB-wide.
- **2026 is 115 PA.** It clears the 100-PA floor, but read direction, not decimals.
- **Two wOBA bases, labelled.** House wOBA (K44 nresults) for ranks and KR-1; Statcast-basis wOBA (WB-1) only beside xwOBA (XW-1).
- **KR-1 and CE-1 are provisional** (first use). KR-1's line explains 34% of the pool's wOBA spread; the rest is contact, sequencing and defense.
- **The luck context is post-hoc.** PR-1 graded the change from 2021–22; the pool-median comparison was added after scoring and is not graded.
- **Money is AAV basis.** No deferrals, signing-bonus timing or tax effects. ERA, ER and minor-league lines are carry-ins, never computed on.
- **No medical inference.** Velocity is reported, not explained; nothing here claims an injury.
- **The client frame undercounts him** by 483 pitches (O-26 name-dedup) and carries 18 NLDS pitches in 2025 (SRC-1). Governed numbers will not match the client CSV for 2015–22 or 2025.

Receipts: `out/dp_uc62_*` (CSV/JSON/PNG). Governance trail: `Agents for Data Products/data-products/uc-pps-038-walker-phillies-career-recap-001/` (00–07, BID). DQ 15 PASS / 0 WARN / 0 FAIL.